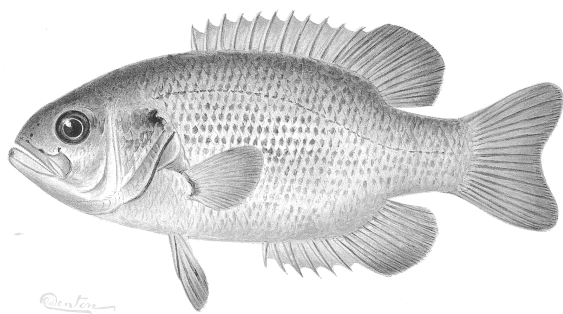


Rock Bass

Ambloplites rupestris

Red-eyed, abundant, and always willing



Rock Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	A bright red eye , a large mouth for a panfish, and rows of dark spots along the scale lines giving a dotted-stripe look. The clinching check: six spines in the anal fin . Bluegill, pumpkinseed and the other sunfish have three.
Colour	It can flush from pale olive to near-black in seconds, so colour alone will mislead you. Use the eye and the anal spines.
Size here	6–9 in. Abundant on Pine Lake, whose gravel bottom is exactly what they want.
Spawn	Late May into June at 60–70 °F, in shallow nests scooped on gravel near rock, often close to smallmouth beds.
Eats	Crayfish, insect larvae and small fish. Aggressive well out of proportion to its size.
Season	

Where and how

Habitat	Rock, gravel, rip-rap and boulder. Pine spots 2, 3, 4 and 8 ; North spots 3 and 4 . Wherever you fish for smallmouth you will find rock bass first.
Depth	2–20 ft, tight to the bottom and tight to cover.
Rig	They will take anything. A split-shot rig with a worm, a small jig, a tube — it hardly matters. <i>see the split shot sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.
Eating	Perfectly good — white and mild, if a little softer than perch. Under-appreciated.

Use them

Rock bass are the fish that saves a slow morning with a child, and they are the fish that tells you your smallmouth spot has the right bottom. Neither is a small thing. If you are catching rock bass on a new piece of structure, keep working it.

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